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ver the past few decades, most urban Indian families have been touched by the Godrej brand. From

locks and safes to consumer products, electronics and real estate, the group has diversified into various businesses over the years. Helming the flagship company of the 125-year-old group is Jamshyd N. Godrej, Chairman & MD of Godrej & Boyce. In a freewheeling interview with *Business Today's* Global Business Editor *Udayan Mukherjee*, Godrej explains what it will take to boost manufacturing in India, the synergy between his B2B and B2C businesses and the road ahead. Edited excerpts:

Q: You know, I spent most of my career looking at the stock market. And I would often wonder why your companies were privately held. Why was Godrej & Boyce not listed on the bourses? You have such iconic businesses. Why did you choose to never take the company public and do an IPO?

A: Well, it's a complex issue. But you know, the main reason to go to the public is that if you need to raise finances for your expansion and growth, then you would go to the public. I think we always had strong cash flows and adequate resources for our businesses. And we never felt the need to go public.

Q: That's one reason to go public. The other is to share your wealth and fortune with shareholders. Even going forward, you don't feel that Godrej & Boyce and its allied businesses could ever see an IPO?

A: You know, nobody will ever say never. But for the foreseeable future, I don't see that happening. Nobody can really predict exactly what should be done or can be done. So I would not rule it out, but I would not say that this is something that is being planned.

Q: Let me talk about the group that you are at the helm of because it has very diverse

businesses. At one end you're looking at appliances, which is very successful; and then there is aerospace, electronics, there's capital goods. Do you want to keep it all under one umbrella? Or do you think these diverse businesses should be separated, even demerged, and they can be run as independent and strong entities on their own right?

A: That's a fair question. My view is that the strength of Godrej & Boyce is the diversity of its businesses and the complementary nature of many of them. If you look historically, we expanded into the businesses in which we are for good historical reasons... now, whether those historical reasons hold for the future or not is a different matter. I have always found that there is enormous benefit to the diversity of our businesses. About two-thirds of our businesses are related to consumers, directly or indirectly. And one-third are essentially industrial businesses, which make things like forklift trucks, equipment for the oil and gas industry, etc. Newer businesses in the past 30-40 years have been aerospace and defence, etc. So, I see that there are a lot of commonalities in two-thirds of the businesses, which are all consumer-facing, and one-third which are all B2B facing. I look at it basically as these two major buckets that we work with; yes, they are different businesses, but there's a lot of synergy amongst them.

"India is a young country with greater disposable income, and we sell all over the country. And so, I don't see that (consumption patterns) as a problem area at all. In fact, I see it as a big growth engine"

Q: Now, that's a fine distinction, Jamshyd, and I want to talk a little bit more about it. The government's capex thrust has been something that has been very pronounced over the last couple of years. And we've seen the issues of inflation, Covid-19, etc., and consumption has gone through a few bumpy